triggered a renewed spate of terrorism. Baitullah Mehsud had claimed that he had more than 200 suicide bombers who would strike the cities of Pakistan. Thus, even after his death, they retaliated with more force and ferocity.

The fact that Pakistan did not form a national counter-terrorism strategy is beyond comprehension. It resulted in misdirected and episodic efforts to counter terrorists who kept persistently striking at their targets quite conveniently. Is it because the government wanted to be selective in striking at the terrorists of its choice? Some observers had also accused Pakistan of selective approach to cracking down on various organisations. For example, Hizb ut-Tahrir, which was not involved in carrying out terrorist activities, had been banned, whereas some other organisations, known for their involvement in violence and militancy, kept operating with new names under the federal and provincial governments. The then Interior Minister of Pakistan, Mr Abdul Rehman Malik, while addressing a UK-based think tank reportedly alleged that all terrorists arrested in Pakistan had visited the Tablighi Jamaat centre at Raiwind, near Lahore. In fact, Tablighi Jamaat was a missionary organisation, which had no record of involvement in violence or terrorism. Political opponents criticised him for using it as a political ploy because Raiwind is in Punjab, ruled by the opposing political party PML (N) at that time. Earlier he had blamed 'Punjabi Taliban', based in southern Punjab, for militancy and suggested military operation against them. However, he quickly retracted his statement. Therefore, political rivalry between the PPP, ruling at the Centre, and the PML (N), ruling in the Punjab, remained a cogent reason for their inactivity against the terrorists, militants and religious extremists. Rather they used the terrorism card to pip the opponents. Had there been a CT strategy, they would have not been able to 'divert attention to speculative statements with dubious implications' (*Dawn*, 2011).

Bryan Hunt had stated in one of his cables to the US Department of State that the local officials criticised the PML (N)-led provincial and the PPP-led federal governments for their 'failure to act' against 'extremist madrasahs, or known prominent leaders, such as Jaish-e-Muhammad's leader Masood Azhar'. The Bahawalpur district Nazim at that time told Hunt that despite repeatedly highlighting the threat posed by extremist groups and indoctrination centres to the provincial and federal governments, he had received 'no support' in dealing with the issue